



Such an approach was also attempted with the introduction of the Task Pane in the 2003 iteration of Microsoft Office. The new interface of Office 2007 (or Office 12) builds upon this task-based groundwork. Let's say you're working with Microsoft Word. Over time, you will use certain elements of the software—you will work with fonts, play around with paragraphs, use the clipboard, or maybe the search feature, and so on. You might wish to insert a chart from Excel, or even a normal table. Finally, you might want to proof the document for spelling or grammar and then send it across to a colleague via e-mail.

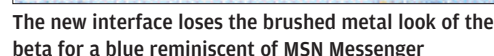


Menus have been largely eliminated: the Ribbon is now the replacement for menus as well as toolbars. The Ribbon is also what contains the tabs we talked about. Although the tabs are a very logical way of presenting options, you could very well spend some time hunting for a feature under tabs, rather than hunting under menus. However, a tab is infinitely easier to navigate

than a menu. A new “Office button” has taken the place of the File menu; what this adds is primarily collaboration tools.

In our experience, working with this tab-based, task-oriented user interface has certainly made the process of discovering features much easier than under the menu-driven regime. It also reduces the number of clicks and mouse movements needed to work a certain feature, which is indicative of friendly interface design.

Apart from fighting menus, previous versions of the Office suite have been guilty of throwing arcane bits of information at us users. What



exactly is a gutter, and why does my page need one? How does Mail Merge work? Don't throw a histogram at me, please; all I wish to do is reduce the contrast of this inserted image. You then have to wrestle with relics such as the Apply button. Not being able to see what an option does to your precious document's formatting without clicking on Apply is an exercise in frustration, and invariably involves hitting Undo at least once. You then have to dive back into the menus for yet another go at the fine science of word processing.

Office Word 2007 introduces a slew of features which go a long, long way in reducing some of this frustration. The most visible of them, pardon the pun, is the ability to see changes live. Office Word 2007, for example, allows you to view different paragraph styles by just hovering over the Quick Formatting stub under the Write tab. Selecting fonts is also a more pleasurable experience thanks to immediate visual feedback. An inserted image can similarly be tweaked for

